

Summary of ‘The Productivity of Professions: Evidence from the Emergency Department’ by David C. Chan and Yiqun Chen (2024)

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Broad Question

The authors seek to understand the differences in productivity between groups who perform overlapping tasks, though vary in background: nurse practitioners and physicians.

Specific Question

Using VHA data, the authors look to ascertain the productivity of the two groups by leveraging quasi-experimental variation in availability of NP’s and physicians. They seek to understand the effect on resource use and health outcomes for patients.

Policy Relevance

This is a useful undertaking policy wise since it can inform policy regarding physician availability and thus influence health outcomes for patients. Further, it can help to augment NP programs to better equip this group to act as a closer proxy for a physician.

Economic Relevance

Economically, this paper is able to leverage a quasi-experimental setting to analyze the difference between two groups which are, at least in my view, sort of viewed as substitutable at times. Thus, we are able to see the validity of this claim as well as use it as a launch point for further research.

What We Learn

Broadly, the authors find NP's are less productive, using more resources and achieving worse patient outcomes. NP's also rely on external information more and less risk taking when prescribing, potentially leading to loss of action in thwarting a health problem. They find these costs are minimized in a setting in which the NP's are assigned healthier patients, thus implying an "easier" case. Overall, they find that rather than trying to maximize average productivity, the institutions hiring professionals should seek to optimally assign their professionals, thus getting the most out of each unit.